speak against Muslims earlier. That psychological advantage has come to Hindus these days.' He was the Hindu pradhan of a village that was primarily Muslim, in an area of UP where the minority population is high. 'It's a question of balance. Earlier the default power was with Muslims, now it is with Hindus. Earlier Muslim leaders could do whatever they wanted to in these three–four districts. Basically, law and order is better. Earlier girls used to run away a lot. They don't anymore because of this.'[28] This was only his perception, of course, but it offered a window into why so many voters moved to the BJP.

When they are questioned about Muslims, BJP leaders always point to government schemes, saying there is no religious bias in them. On that count, they are not wrong. Chouhan's village by the Shakumbhari Devi temple is a case in point. Nine houses were approved to be built in the village in 2020, under PMAY-G: six were for Muslim households, three for Hindu ones. Twenty-three houses had been approved in 2019. Of these, twenty-one were for Muslim families, two Hindu. In the neighbouring village, ninety-eight houses were approved in 2020. Of these, twenty-eight were for Hindus or Dalits, seventy were for Muslim families.[29] This is because Muslims made up the bulk of the population in the region. Of course, it was their right to have access to these schemes, and it would have been unconstitutional for the state to discriminate against them even if it wanted to. Government data shows that 11.9 per cent of over 18 million houses sanctioned in India under PMAY-G between 2016 and 2020 was for religious minorities. In UP, the minorities accounted for 10.9 per cent of such grants.[30] Similarly, they accounted for 10 per cent of all loans under the Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana (PMMY), which provides credit to micro-enterprises to bring them into the formal financial system.[31]

I asked the pradhan if access to welfare schemes meant that some Muslims were voting for the BJP. He answered, 'The poor will vote. If you get rations for five kids and you earn for two, you will vote. It is a simple, straight thing if you get benefits.'

In a state where the government put up name-and-shame banners identifying those who protested against the CAA in March 2020, the BJP has clearly bet its political fortunes on an